

S05-05 - The Peak

Player text

It all comes at once: the dead clawing up faster, the wraiths pressing in, the Custodian's glow guttering like a candle in wind. The clock is close, but so is disaster. Every choice now costs something: guard her and leave a friend exposed, or save the friend and let her take the hit that sets you all back. There is no clean way through. There is only what you are willing to give.

Public objective

Survive the peak and drive the countdown home.

Raw source

- Id: S05-05
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-FIVE
- Sectiontitle: Act Five: The Ward Renewal
- Title: The Peak
- Shorttitle: Hold or Break
- Order: 605
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S05-05-soul-audit-wraiths.png
- Alt: Soul-Audit Wraiths scene art for The Ward Renewal.
- Caption: The peak asks what the party saves when it cannot save everything cleanly.
- Mood: The Ward Renewal
- Gmgoal: Run the peak HOLD/BREAK choice and let resource spends, protection, and sacrifice decide the outcome track.
- Publicobjective: Survive the peak and drive the countdown home.
- Readaloud: It all comes at once: the dead clawing up faster, the wraiths pressing in, the Custodian's glow guttering like a candle in wind. The clock is close, but so is disaster. Every choice now costs something: guard her and leave a friend exposed, or save the friend and let her take the hit that sets you all back. There is no clean way through. There is only what you are willing to give.
- Gmnotes: No PC is required to land the final blow. Let any meaningful action create the final tick if fiction supports it.
- Gmscript: Say: "All-in time. Spend Hope, boons, big abilities, tag-team moments, and last good ideas. You cannot cover it all, so what you choose to save becomes the ending."
- Gmreadaloud: It all comes at once. The Custodian's glow gutters like a candle in wind. The clock is close, but so is disaster.
- Gmcheckboxlist: Threaten the Custodian honestly. Offer Death Move choices heroically if a PC marks their last HP: Blaze of Glory, Avoid Death, or Risk It All. Use HOLD if she is protected and the party drives the countdown home cleanly. Use BREAK if someone falls, she is hit badly, or the win is bought with a severe cost. Seed

ritual_outcome as clean, costly, or pyrrhic; finalize protected_whom.

- Gmprivate: Custodian death remains a Kyle canon flag. Use dying only as a marked unresolved possibility unless ruled live.
- Playertakeaway: This is the moment you will remember: give everything, choose who you save, and finish it.
- Storytakeaway: You cannot save everything, so what you choose to save becomes the ending.
- Mechanictakeaway: Peak play spends Hope, boons, tag-team actions, Death Moves, and final countdown ticks to write ritual_outcome and protected_whom.
- Rollcards: s05-05-ground-an-untethered-ally S05-05 Ground an Untethered ally Ground an Untethered ally Presence Knowledge Presence Knowledge 13 Presence calls them back; Knowledge disputes the audit logic. A soul stays loose while the ritual strains. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. A soul stays loose while the ritual strains. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time, noise, leverage, or...
- Entityids: soul-audit-wraith market-correction ritual-countdown whitefire-custodian soul-audit-memory-shard soulspire-solutions route-ledger fear
- Entities: soul-audit-wraith Soul-Audit Wraith enemy Enemy / Combatant assets/icons/enemy.png assets/npc-images/soul-audit-wraith/portrait_base.png SOHL AW-dit RAYTH A terrifying wraith that attacks memory, vulnerability, and soul tether. Soul-debt collector threat. Soul-Audit Wraith a cold memory predator that makes care feel like an unpaid balance A predator made of policy, hunting where debt, ward-failure, and fear overlap. The original person wanted release from a debt that taught them to collect others, and that single unpaid wanting is the only crack in the ledger. Convert protection, memory, and fear into collectable balance. Please state the value of what you refuse to lose. a cold memory predator that makes care feel like an unpaid balance npc-profile-v1 NPC_System_Packet + image-informed hardening True Soul-Audit Wraith a cold memory predator that makes care feel like an unpaid balance A blue-white skeletal auditor drifts inside a torn hood, ledger-light spilling from a dead chest medallion while spectral papers curl around one arm. Soul-Audit Wraith: a cold memory predator that makes care feel like an unpaid balance Soul-Audit Wraith SOHL AW-dit RAYTH a cold memory predator...
- Clueids: route-ledger market-correction soul-audit-memory-shard legacy-security-badge
- Statecontrols: ward_stability Ward Stability select fragile stable ritual_prep Ritual Prep select unready ready keystone_understanding Keystone Understanding select surface deep ritual_countdown Ritual Countdown number 10 8 ritual_outcome Ritual Outcome select unresolved clean costly pyrrhic protected_whom Protected Whom select unresolved custodian party hush shared custodian_fate Custodian Fate select

unresolved well drained dying strixwolf_disposition Strixwolf Disposition select
 unresolved calm hostile killed strixwolf_outcome Strixwolf Outcome select unresolved
 calmed helped avoided attacked killed strixwolf_trust Strixwolf Trust number 3
 strixwolf_blood_debt Strixwolf Blood Debt checkbox bramble_outcome Bramble Outcome
 select unresolved killed captured spared negotiated escaped let_cargo
 bramble_truth_learned Bramble Truth Learned checkbox package_status Package Status
 select held lost hush_trust Hush Trust select low neutral high custodian_route
 Custodian Route select unknown safe dangerous ward_awareness Ward Awareness select
 none seed aware festival_boon Festival Boon select none charm favor market_find
 goodwill custodian_trust Custodian Trust select low neutral high hush_clues Hush...

- Mechanics: stress vulnerable reaction-rolls presence knowledge countdown death-move tag-team-roll hope fear untethered group-attack
- Playerquestions: Who do you stand in front of? What have you been saving for now? If you cannot cover everything, what do you choose to save?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in Soul-Audit Wraiths that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Choicesconsequences: HOLD: protect her and finish the clock. The Custodian stays upright and the countdown reaches 0. Set ritual_outcome=clean if the party stays intact; costly if resources are spent hard. S05-06 lands as earned relief. ritual_outcome=clean/costly; custodian_fate=well/drained Reward: strong victory with named effort. player-visible BREAK: save a friend and let the center suffer. A friend survives, but the ritual takes a hit. Tick ritual_countdown +1 or set custodian_fate=drained/dying depending on table result. S05-06 becomes costly or pyrrhic. ritual_outcome=costly/pyrrhic; protected_whom=party Both: people saved, ward cost rises. player-visible Spend a boon or Hope now. An earned resource changes the peak. festival_boon, Hope, tag-team action, or class feature cancels pressure or creates a final tick. Prior choices become visible in the finale. ritual_outcome improves one step if fiction supports it Reward: five-act payoff. player-visible Death Move triggers. A PC facing last HP gets a heroic choice. Blaze of Glory, Avoid Death, or Risk It All; record protected_whom and ritual_outcome. The denouement honors the choice by name. protected_whom=shared/party; ritual_outcome=costly or...
- Lootclues: Use Wraith memory shards table
- Handoutids: Memory shard Guaranteed seed Guaranteed seed Earned seed Earned seed
- Sourcescenelug: S05-05-soul-audit-wraiths
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_SCENE_RESEARCH.md
dist/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_MAPS_AND_LOCATIONS.md
- References: Peak battle skeleton map #MAP-COMBAT-S05-05 Peak battle wraith map #MAP-COMBAT-S05-06
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. Soul-Audit Wraiths bear

audit glyphs and say, "Unauthorized soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."

REFLAVOR GUARANTEED A defeated wraith leaves a Soulspire compliance tag or coil-credit token instead of natural remains. ADD GUARANTEED Wraiths ignore forest creatures and home only on ritual soul-magic. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 A player can read the markings and name Soulspire without the GM naming it first. ADD EARNED Knowledge Medium 15 Optional flag: Legacy Skeletons carry scraps of old corporate credentials. FLAG SEED Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unauthorized soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit." REFLAVOR GUARANTEED A defeated wraith leaves a Soulspire compliance tag or coil-credit token instead of natural remains. ADD GUARANTEED Wraiths ignore forest creatures and home only on ritual soul-magic. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 A player can read the markings and...

- Livetools: encounter S05-05 MAP-COMBAT-S05-05 MAP-S05-03 pages/combat/s05-05.html
- Percharacterlayer: khari-nix Khari Nix The sacrifice Natural body for the protect-choice: Custodian, ally, or center at her own cost. Can step into the hardest pressure without becoming mandatory. Khari, this is the moment a guardian lives for. Who do you put yourself between? garrick-reed Garrick Reed All-in strike Can spend Hope, Tag Team, or a big Warrior push to drop the threat menacing the Custodian. Can bring the clock home through decisive action. Garrick, go all-in on the thing about to hit her. Want to end this? marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind Duty vs people A last big spell can clear field pressure or shield the Custodian. Her choice mirrors duty versus people without gating victory. Marlowe, one big push left. Protect her, or protect the party? Your call says who you've become. barnacle Barnacle Clutch save Can yank an Untethered or falling ally out of danger. Can make the save nobody sees coming. Barnacle, someone's about to fall. Want to be the reason they don't? varian-soto Varian Soto Clean shot Can land a final ranged burst to defeat the last threat and tick the clock to 0. Can end pressure from the edge. Varian, one clean shot could end it. Want to take it?
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway This is the moment you will remember: give everything, choose who you save, and finish it. "Whatever you have been saving, now. Decide who you stand in front of and bring the clock home." "Throw your best at the biggest threat, body-block the Custodian, spend a boon, or save the teammate about to fall. No wrong answer, only yours." Make this a choice scene, not a math exercise. countdown death-move hope tag-team-roll Story takeaway You cannot save everything, so what you choose to save becomes the ending. "You cannot cover it all. What you sacrifice here is the story you will tell about tonight." "There is no hidden trick. The clock can be won; the question is at what cost." HOLD/BREAK should be visible and emotionally fair. countdown death-move hope tag-team-roll Mechanic takeaway Peak play spends Hope, boons, tag-team actions, Death Moves, and final countdown ticks to write ritual_outcome and protected_whom. "All-in time: spend Hope, festival boon, tag-team, class features. If someone hits last HP, Death Move is live and heroic." "Every Custodian hit is +1; every defeat or true pressure removal is -1. Near the end, one choice can change clean to costly or costly...
- Playerbeats: s05-05-all-at-once Peak All at once assets/scenes/S05-05-soul-audit-wraiths.png Soul-Audit Wraiths scene art for The Ward Renewal. The dead claw faster, the wraiths press in, and the Custodian's glow gutters in the wind. The dead claw faster, the wraiths press in, and the Custodian's glow gutters in the wind. The dead claw faster, the wraiths press in, and the Custodian's glow gutters in the wind. text-first s05-05-choice Choice The choice assets/scenes/S05-05-soul-audit-

wraiths.png Soul-Audit Wraiths scene art for The Ward Renewal. Guard her and leave a friend exposed, or save the friend and let her take the hit. There is no clean way through. Guard her and leave a friend exposed, or save the friend and let her take the hit. There is no clean way through. Guard her and leave a friend exposed, or save the friend and let her take the hit. There is no clean way through. text-first s05-05-drive All In Drive it home assets/scenes/S05-05-soul-audit-wraiths.png Soul-Audit Wraiths scene art for The Ward Renewal. Spend Hope, boons, big abilities, tag-team moments, and last good ideas. Bring the clock home. Spend Hope, boons, big abilities, tag-team moments, and last good ideas. Bring the...

- Gmbeats: s05-05-all-at-once Peak All at once Say: "This is the peak. The table should feel that every choice matters now." The dead claw faster, the wraiths press in, and the Custodian's glow gutters in the wind. All prior pressure converges. Peak state decides ritual_outcome. Players feel the climax pressure. Player takeaway Players feel the climax pressure. "This is the peak. The table should feel that every choice matters now." "The table-facing answer is: Players feel the climax pressure." Use this beat to give the players one visible next action: protect the center, read the field, spend prep, name who they shield, or choose what truth leaves with them. countdown fear Story takeaway All prior pressure converges. "This is the peak. The table should feel that every choice matters now." "The story answer is: All prior pressure converges." Tie the answer to a visible Act 5 consequence: the ward steadies, the Custodian suffers, Hush is protected, or the final report changes who owns the truth. countdown fear Mechanic takeaway Peak state decides ritual_outcome. "This is the peak. The table should feel that every choice matters now." "The active table procedure is: Peak state decides...
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 8500
- Playersafeprojection: S05-05 scene The Peak assets/scenes/S05-05-soul-audit-wraiths.png Soul-Audit Wraiths scene art for The Ward Renewal. The peak asks what the party saves when it cannot save everything cleanly. The Ward Renewal Survive the peak and drive the countdown home. It all comes at once: the dead clawing up faster, the wraiths pressing in, the Custodian's glow guttering like a candle in wind. The clock is close, but so is disaster. Every choice now costs something: guard her and leave a friend exposed, or save the friend and let her take the hit that sets you all back. There is no clean way through. There is only what you are willing to give. s05-05-all-at-once Peak All at once assets/scenes/S05-05-soul-audit-wraiths.png Soul-Audit Wraiths scene art for The Ward Renewal. The dead claw faster, the wraiths press in, and the Custodian's glow gutters in the wind. The dead claw faster, the wraiths press in, and the Custodian's glow gutters in the wind. The dead claw faster, the wraiths press in, and the Custodian's glow gutters in the wind. text-first s05-05-choice Choice The choice assets/scenes/S05-05-soul-audit-wraiths.png Soul-Audit Wraiths scene art for The Ward Renewal. Guard her and leave...
- Companionmapids: MAP-S05-03 MAP-COMBAT-S05-05 MAP-LOC-open-valetm-ritual-site
- Slidenumbers: 71
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-M-DEATH unconscious-state unconscious-state M20 S05-05 high mandatory first-time Unconscious, Not Gone This one-shot keeps last HP gentle and recoverable. You are not dead. At last HP in this module default, you become

Unconscious. You can return when an ally restores 1 HP or after a long rest. Last HP handling wiki/mechanic/unconscious-state stalled-player-recovery Advanced death moves wiki/mechanic/death-moves-advanced stalled-player-recovery True Protect table confidence during the most stressful hit-point moment. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True SPOT-M-TAGTEAM tag-team-roll tag-team-roll M10 S05-05 high mandatory beat:peak Tag Team Moment Two PCs can make one dramatic move together. A player can spend 3 Hope to initiate a Tag Team Roll with another PC. Both players roll, then choose one result to apply to both of them. This counts as one action roll and is once per player per session. Tag Team wiki/mechanic/tag-team teach-by-example Give the finale a clean, rules-backed teamwork button. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True SPOT-C-BARNACLE-LATE barnacle Barnacle late S05-05 high optional beat:peak Barnacle, Read the Market Endgame money trail gives them a...
- Spotlightsummary: 2 1

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